

Rodenstock

Ophthalmic lens manufacturer | Germany | Private (sponsor-owned, LBO)

Fitch B- IDR, Stable (06-Jul-26) S&P B- (CFR) Moody's Withdrawn (last: Caa1, 02-Apr-25)

SPONSOR Apax (~73%) / Mubadala (~24%) SECTOR Health Care Equipment & Services CEO Vacant since 30-Jun-26 CURRENCY EUR

EUR 493m

FY25 SALES (FITCH, -3.8%)

22.0%

FY25 FITCH-ADJ. EBITDA MARGIN

8.5x

EBITDA LEVERAGE (END-2025)

~EUR 48m

LIQUIDITY HEADROOM (END-2025)

BUSINESS DESCRIPTION

Munich-based manufacturer of ophthalmic lenses, founded 1877, c.5,000 employees, six production sites, sold through opticians and retail chains in 85+ countries. Built around premium individualised lenses: the B.I.G. VISION biometric range (610 patents; Fitch: 40% of core sales from highly differentiated products) and MyCon myopia-control lenses for children (+62% sales, 2024). Strong profitability versus peers — 61% gross margin, 22% Fitch-adjusted EBITDA margin — from proprietary technology and lower-cost manufacturing in Eastern Europe/Asia. Sold its eyewear division to De Rigo in Dec-2022, leaving a lenses-only business. Small versus EssilorLuxottica, Hoya and Zeiss, constraining Fitch's competitive-positioning score to 'bb-'.

Corporate history: second period of lender-level stress. Sold by founders to Permira (2003) then Bridgepoint (2006); 2010-11 standstill on EUR370m debt. Compass Partners control 2016-2021. Apax bought the group from Compass in Apr-2021 (EV EUR1.275-1.5bn, c.10.2x 2021 EBITDA) alongside Mubadala (~24%), backed by a EUR610m equity cheque. Facilities amended and upsized May-2022. Apax has been exploring a refinancing since Mar-2025; **none has completed** (confirmed directly, and consistent with Fitch's 06-Jul-2026 report, which rates the existing structure and conditions the rating on refinancing within six months).

SITUATION OVERVIEW

The EUR840m TLB (Jun-2028) and EUR125m RCF (Dec-2027) have not been refinanced as of 27-Sep-2026. Apax has been trying since Mar-2025; in that time leverage has risen to 8.5x, FCF has turned negative, the RCF has been drawn to 71%, and the CEO has left with no successor named.

FY2024's modest improvement (revenue +1.2% to EUR512.4m, EBITDA +5.1% to EUR128.6m, company basis) did not continue. Fitch reports FY2025 sales of EUR493m (-3.8%) and a 22.0% Fitch-adjusted margin (implies c.EUR108m EBITDA, below the EUR125m the 2021 buyout was marketed on), driven by a soft German market (31% of sales, consumers trading down) and the GrandVision contract phase-out. Fitch expects a further low-single-digit sales decline in 2026 before 3.0-3.2% growth resumes, with the margin recovering to 24.4% on cost savings already executed — but its own leverage forecast (8.0x in 2026, "towards" 7.7x in 2027) stays above its 7.5x downgrade trigger throughout.

No deleveraging or sponsor equity support is on record since 2021. Despite constrained liquidity the company still made a small Croatian bolt-on in Mar-2026 (terms undisclosed). Moody's withdrew its Caa1 rating at the issuer's request (30-Jul-2026), three weeks after Fitch's B- assignment — not tied to any completed transaction. The loans trade at 93.2 (25-Sep-2026), down from the mid-90s pre-downgrade but stable since June: the market is pricing refinancing risk, not a distressed outcome.

KEY CATALYSTS / TRIGGERS TO WATCH

- MATURITY** EUR965m senior secured stack (EUR125m RCF due Dec-27, c.15 months; EUR840m TLB due Jun-28, c.21 months) confirmed NOT refinanced. Fitch's rating is conditioned on a refinancing, or credible plan, within six months of 06-Jul-26 (window closes c.early Jan-27). Fitch's own rating case assumes refinancing only happens in 2027, at a 6% margin vs 5% today — itself evidence the agency does not expect near-term completion.
- LEVERAGE** 8.5x EBITDA leverage at end-2025 (Fitch), forecast 8.0x (2026) and "towards" 7.7x (2027) — both above Fitch's own 7.5x downgrade sensitivity. FY2025 margin (22.0%) sits only 2pp above Fitch's 20% downgrade trigger.
- COVENANT** RCF springing covenant test is live. 9.5x net leverage test triggers at ≥40% drawn (EUR50m of EUR125m); RCF was 71% drawn (EUR89m) at end-2025. No breach reported; covenant-basis headroom not confirmed (Fitch's gross 8.5x sits within c.1.0x of the 9.5x trigger).
- LIQUIDITY** Constrained: c.EUR48m accessible (EUR12m unrestricted cash + EUR36m undrawn RCF) at end-2025, under 10% of FY25 sales. FCF "particularly weak" in 2025; Fitch flags possible downgrade to CCC on underperformance, working-capital swings or higher capex.
- GOVERNANCE** CEO vacant since 30-Jun-26 (Desimoni departed for personal reasons, no successor named); CFO in post only since Feb-2026. Refinancing execution now rests with a leadership team with under 8 months' combined tenure in their current roles.

REVENUE SPLITS (EUR MILLIONS) — FULL SPLIT LAST AVAILABLE FY2020; FY25 TOTAL PER FITCH

By Segment	FY19	FY20	FY25	By Geography	FY19	FY20	FY25
Lenses	377.7 (84%)	344.9 (86%)	<i>n/a</i> ¹	Germany	175.6 (39%)	159.1 (40%)	~153 (31%)
Eyewear (<i>divested Dec-22</i>)	50.3 (11%)	34.6 (9%)	—	Rest of Europe	198.6 (44%)	180.3 (45%)	<i>n/a</i> ¹
Others	21.7 (5%)	21.5 (5%)	<i>n/a</i> ¹	Asia	26.8 (6%)	17.9 (4%)	<i>n/a</i> ¹
Total	449.7	401.0	493	Rest of World	48.6 (11%)	43.6 (11%)	<i>n/a</i> ¹
				Total	449.6	400.9	493

¹ not available - further diligence required; likely source: FY25 audited accounts (Bundesanzeiger) or lender presentation. FY19/20 splits still include the divested Eyewear division (ex-Eyewear, Lenses were c.94-95% of the continuing business). Germany's share fall (40%→31%) mixes a genuine soft German market with the change in perimeter; not separable with data on file.

SUMMARY FINANCIALS (EUR MILLIONS) — THREE DIFFERENT BASES; DO NOT READ AS ONE SERIES					
	FY2019	FY2020	FY2023	FY2024	FY2025
Source / basis	9fin	9fin	Company PR	Company PR	Fitch (Jul-26)
Revenue	449.7	401.0	506.1	512.4	493
Revenue growth	5.8%	(10.8%)	0.2%	1.2%	(3.8%)*
EBITDA (9fin adj.)	94.9	65.7	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹
EBITDA (company-defined)	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	122.3	128.6	<i>n/a</i> ¹
EBITDA (Fitch-adj., derived)	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	~108 ²
EBITDA margin (basis above)	21.1%	16.4%	24.2%	25.1%	22.0%
Gross margin	48.2%	47.3%	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	61% ³
Unlevered FCF	58.1	44.3	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹
Levered FCF	28.4	14.3	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n.a.</i> ⁴
LFCF conversion	29.9%	21.8%	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n.a.</i> ⁴
Total debt (excl. leases/pensions)	478.5	486.0	<i>n/a</i> ¹	c.810 (TLBs only)	c.940⁵
Cash	39.0	74.7	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	28 (12 avail.)
Gross leverage	5.0x	7.4x	<i>n/a</i> ¹	c.6.3x (TLB- only, indic.)	8.5x

* Cross-basis comparison (Fitch FY25 vs company-reported FY24); likely a genuine decline (soft Germany, GrandVision phase-out per Fitch) but a scope/definitional component can't be excluded. ² Analyst calculation (22.0% × EUR493m); Fitch does not publish absolute EBITDA. Part of the gap to company FY24 EBITDA (EUR128.6m) is likely definitional (Fitch typically nets IFRS16 lease costs; company add-backs have historically run EUR8-24m above 9fin's figure) and part genuine — Fitch explicitly states 2025 EBITDA was lower. ³ Fitch-stated; not comparable to 9fin's 47-49% (FY16-20, different perimeter/classification). ⁴ Fitch states FY25 FCF was negative and "particularly weak" but does not disclose the amount; shown per the negative-conversion display rule. ⁵ EUR840m TLB + EUR89m RCF drawn (Fitch); +EUR11m local facilities not included. **Fitch 2026-30 rating case:** low-single-digit sales decline 2026 (GrandVision phase-out) then 3.0-3.2%/yr growth; margin to 24.4% (2026), "towards" 26% (2029/30); leverage 8.0x (2026), "towards" 7.7x (2027, still above the 7.5x downgrade trigger); capex 5.3% of revenue; refinancing assumed in 2027 at 6% margin; no dividends to 2030. Most recent detailed (line-item) financials available as of 31-Dec-2020; most recent headline financials as of 31-Dec-2025 (Fitch).

CAPITAL STRUCTURE (EUR MILLIONS, END-2025 UNLESS STATED) — PRIMARY SOURCE: FITCH 06-JUL-26; NO STRUCTURED 9FIN CAP TABLE EXISTS						
Instrument	Amount	x FY25 EBITDA ²	Rate	Maturity	Price	Rating (F/S/M)
Local facilities (super senior)	11	0.1x	<i>n/a</i> ¹	<i>n/a</i> ¹	n.a.	NR
EUR125m RCF (71% drawn)	89 drawn / 125 commit.	0.8x	<i>n/a</i> ¹	Dec-2027	n.a.	B-/B-/NR ⁵
Term Loan B (per Fitch, single line)	840	7.8x	E+500	Jun-2028	93.18	B-/RR4
Total senior secured debt	940	8.7x		Dec-27/Jun-28		
<i>less: cash</i>	(28)					
Net senior secured debt	912	8.4x				
<i>German pension obligations (unsecured)</i>	230.9 (FY20, stale)	<i>n/m</i>	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.

Unreconciled quantum: Fitch's EUR840m single TLB figure does not tie to the 9fin tranche breakdown (EUR660m due 21-May-28 + EUR150m due 05-Jul-28 = EUR810m) or the 2022 amend-and-restate (EUR660m + EUR170m add-on = EUR830m). EUR660m tranche confirmed via the holder register. Gap of EUR10-30m unresolved; Fitch used as primary since it is the most recent, single source. RCF also shown at EUR125m/Dec-2027 (Fitch) vs EUR120m/21-May-2028 (9fin 2021 origination) — Fitch preferred as more current. ² FY25 EBITDA basis: analyst-derived ~EUR108m (see Summary Financials). ⁵ Fitch rates the TLB/RCF together at B-/RR4; S&P B- per 9fin screener (date/outlook not confirmed); Moody's withdrawn 30-Jul-26 (last B3 at instrument level, Caa1 CFR). Indicative simple discount margins (analyst calc., ignores floor/amortisation): EUR660m tranche c.E+910bps, EUR150m tranche c.E+880bps to respective maturities. Yield to maturity not calculated (needs a EURIBOR forward curve). **Recovery (Fitch, analyst-derived):** going-concern EBITDA c.EUR95m × 5.5x distressed multiple, less 10% admin claims and EUR11m super senior facilities ≈ EUR459m available for

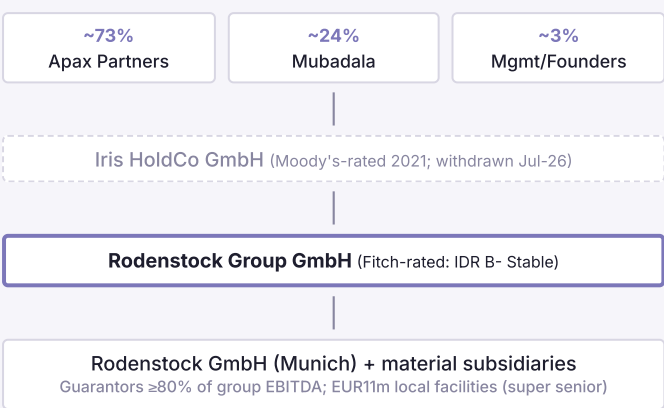
EUR965m of senior secured claims ≈ 48% recovery (within Fitch's published RR4 band of 31-50%) — well below the current 93.18 trading price, consistent with the market pricing a going-concern outcome, not distress.

LIQUIDITY BUILD (EUR MILLIONS, END-2025, FITCH)

Cash on balance sheet	28
Less: restricted (Fitch, not available for debt service)	(16)
Available cash	12
Undrawn RCF (EUR125m less EUR89m drawn)	36
Total accessible liquidity	48

Fitch assesses liquidity as "limited"/"constrained". RCF 71% drawn (springing covenant live, see Catalysts). Known 2026 cash calls (Fitch): restructuring costs c.EUR10m, pension contributions EUR11-12m, capex 5.3% of revenue (c.EUR26m), E+500bps interest on c.EUR930m drawn. No 2026-to-date figure available. Fitch: further underperformance "may result in a downgrade to the CCC category."

SIMPLIFIED GROUP STRUCTURE



No 9fin org chart exists. Structure reconstructed from Fitch (Jul-26) and 9fin articles. Relationship between Iris HoldCo GmbH and the Fitch-rated Rodenstock Group GmbH, and the SFA borrower entity, not confirmed. Security: share pledges, bank accounts, intercompany receivables under one SFA (12-Apr-21, amended and restated 24-May-22). Full guarantor list and restricted group perimeter not available.

MANAGEMENT & SPONSOR REPRESENTATION

Name	Role	Notes
CEO: vacant	Since 30-Jun-26	Desimoni departed (personal reasons); Exec team + Advisory Board running the business; no successor named
Dr. Martina Bentele	CFO (since 01-Feb-26)	Ex-Siemens Energy CAO/Controller; no disclosed leveraged-finance background; leading the refinancing
Roland Dimbath	COO (since 2021)	Longest-serving exec; with Rodenstock since 2006
Apax Partners	Majority sponsor	Leading refi process since Mar-25; no new equity since 2021; Fitch calls policy "aggressive"
Mubadala	Co-investor	Current stake unconfirmed

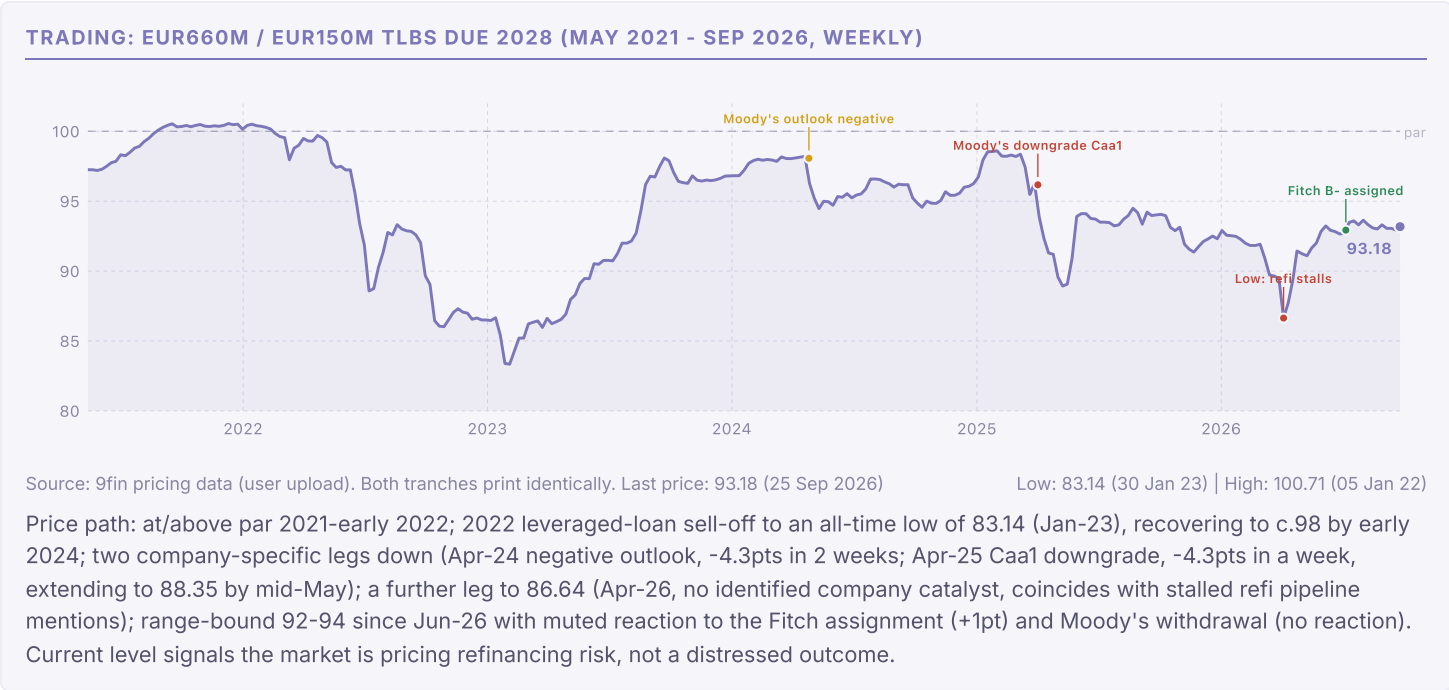
Former CEO Marcus Desimoni (CFO of GN Store Nord/GN Hearing 2016-20, Siemens hearing aids Group CFO 2010-15) and former CFO Dr. Mani Herold (left Mar-25 for VTG; ex-Pfleiderer CFO, c.15yrs Goldman Sachs/Merrill Lynch) both departed during the refinancing process. Herold, the executive with the most capital-markets experience, left shortly after the Mar-25 refinancing exploration began.

RECENT NEWS & EVENTS

Date	Event
04 Aug 26	CEO Desimoni steps down (30-Jun-26); no successor named
03 Aug 26	9fin LevFin pipeline: refi "Stale but Not Forgotten", not "Completed"
30 Jul 26	Moody's withdraws all ratings on issuer's request (last: Caa1 stable)
06 Jul 26	Fitch assigns first-time B- IDR, Stable; existing EUR840m TLB rated B-/RR4
01 Apr 26	9fin LevFin pipeline: still "Potential Debt Financing", timing TBC
31 Mar 26	Acquires Croatian lens distributors NI-VA Lens and DEA Lens Project
30 Sep 25	Dr. Martina Bentele (Siemens Energy) named CFO, effective 01-Feb-26
12 Sep 25	9fin: refi "ongoing" (last pipeline mention; drops out next edition)
14 May 25	FY24 results: revenue EUR512.4m (+1.2%), adj. EBITDA EUR128.6m (+5.1%)

Date	Event
16 Apr 25	Exec team restructured; CEO covers CFO role ad interim after Herold's exit
02 Apr 25	Moody's downgrades to Caa1 from B3, stable outlook
21 Mar 25	9fin: Apax explores private credit refi of EUR810m TLB; loans quoted 95.5
19 Dec 24	CFO Dr. Mani Herold to leave for VTG Group (effective 01-Apr-25)
25 Apr 24	Moody's affirms B3, outlook to negative from stable
12 Dec 22	Eyewear division sold to De Rigo; refocus on lenses-only
24 May 22	SFA amended and restated; EUR150-170m add-on TLB issued
20 May 21	EUR660m 7yr cov-lite TLB + EUR120m RCF priced, backing Apax/Mubadala buyout

17 of 21 identified credit-relevant items shown (space); full list with sources in the backing JSON. Excluded as routine: a regional press release, an ESG/compliance note, and five product-award releases (Oct-25 to Apr-26). All links checked live on 27-Sep-2026; the FY24 results link requires a 9fin login.



DEBT HOLDINGS: EUR660M TLB (21 HOLDERS IDENTIFIED, UPDATED 16-SEP-2026)			
Holder	Amount (EUR m)	% Held	Cumulative %
Intermediate Capital Group plc	95.0	14.39%	14.39%
Palmer Square Capital Management	35.7	5.40%	19.79%
Trinitas Capital Management	32.4	4.92%	24.71%
Onex Credit Partners	27.6	4.19%	28.90%
CIFC Asset Management	24.0	3.64%	32.54%
Barings LLC	20.9	3.17%	35.71%
Chenavari Investment Management	16.5	2.50%	38.21%
Bain Capital Credit	16.4	2.48%	40.69%
King Street Capital Management	16.2	2.45%	43.14%
CVC Credit Partners	13.0	1.97%	45.11%
Total top 10	297.7	45.11%	45.11%
<i>Other identified holders (11)</i>	85.7	13.00%	58.11%
<i>Unidentified</i>	276.6	41.89%	100.00%

Source: 9fin Holders and Transactions screen (user upload, updated 16-Sep-2026). Predominantly CLO managers. Top 6 hold 35.71% — close to blocking a two-thirds majority lender vote on standard LMA thresholds (not confirmed from the SFA). Holder data for the EUR150m tranche and RCF lender group not available.

Recommendation: Add to Restructuring Watchlist

All three triggers are present. **Maturity wall:** EUR965m of senior secured debt (RCF due Dec-27, TLB due Jun-28) remains unrefinanced after 18 months of sponsor-led effort; Fitch's own six-month refinancing window closes c.early Jan-2027, and its

rating case does not expect a deal before 2027, at a higher (6%) margin. **Liquidity:** only c.EUR48m accessible at end-2025, FCF negative, Fitch flags possible downgrade to CCC. **Covenant:** the RCF's 9.5x springing test is live (71% drawn); no breach reported but headroom unconfirmed. Execution risk is compounded by a vacant CEO seat and a CFO eight months into the role leading the refinancing.

Fitch's own recovery analysis implies c.48% recovery on the senior secured stack in a distressed scenario (RR4) — well below the current 93.2 trading price, meaning the market has not yet priced that outcome. **Next steps:** watch for a refinancing launch, amend-and-extend, or sponsor equity commitment before early Jan-2027; the CEO appointment; FY2025 audited accounts; and Fitch's review at the end of its six-month window.